

U/G in Extended: Cool!

by Jeff Cunningham

I can say with a reasonable degree of certainty that I've played more U/G Madness in Extended than any other person on this earth. While my results have merely been consistently solid (2 PT Top 32s, a GP T8, and a slow grind into masters,) this constant practice with the deck has given me insights into it that I suspect many miss. I think there are more misconceptions surrounding this deck than almost any other. U/Gs base is so forgiving that many incarnations of the deck can have positive results, but I believe that by truly understanding what makes the deck work you can maximize your success with it.

Here is the list I played at PT Columbus to 29th place:

4 Careful Study
4 Deep Analysis
4 Circular Logic
4 Daze
2 Intuition
2 Wonder
4 Aquamoeba
1 Gigapede
4 Wild Mongrel
4 Basking Rootwalla
4 Arrogant Wurm
4 Chrome Mox
4 Yavimaya Coast
9 Island
6 Forest

SB:

4 Chill
4 Gilded Drake
4 Submerge
3 Seal of Removal

This deck is tuned for a Rock-heavy metagame (note the Gigapede,) but I think it carries over to the current

field. I don't think anything changes, except the sideboard if your local metagame is pretty specific. This sideboard covers a lot of bases, though, with cards that are cheap and fit within the decks gameplan. In any Extended tournament you play in, it's likely every card in the board will come in at some point, and that's usually a sign of a strong sideboard. If you had to cut something to make room, I would suggest a couple Submerges.

A few comments on card quantities:

4 Deep Analysis: I can always tell who has not done their homework with this deck when I see a list that has only one, two or even three Deep Analysis. This is a crucial card, far more so in Extended than it ever was in Standard or Block.

This is because, firstly, discard (Duress, Cabal Therapy,) is very prominent in Extended, and it's important to be able to rebuild a ripped-apart hand quickly if necessary, to ensure pressure is put on the opponent in a timely manner. Because of Deep Analysis flashback, it essentially has protection from discard effects, which offsets the vulnerability of your madness outlets when they're in your hand (without a Deep Analysis in your hand, a discarded Mongrel can mean an entire hand of Madness cards stranded with it, it's just a temporary set-back.)

Secondly, Chrome Mox is legal. Chrome Mox speeds the deck up the turn at the cost of a card, and Deep Analysis makes sure you never feel that card disadvantage; it ensures that even with that added speed, you never run out of gas. In Extended, speed is something you want to facilitate.

Thirdly, is the important note that the card advantage given by Deep Analysis is relevant in Extended. In the Standard and Block formats U/G madness was played in, MBC was at its most powerful. Even if U/G was drawing four or five cards in the late game, it was still often drawing dead in the face of a lethal Shade, or Mirari-powered spells. This is not the case in current

Extended, where many popular decks (Rock, RDW, Psychatog, Mirror,) follow a fairly straightforward one-for-one attrition plan. Without the maximum number of Deep Analysis, these matchups become more difficult.

Fourthly, the deck needs a certain amount of cards that can be discarded at an advantage, and this is one of the few suitable for Extended. Both because Extended is faster than Standard and Block were, and because it offers a larger card pool (because Daze exists, there is greater competition for spots in the deck,) a lot of the decks former flashback staples are unsuitable. I would put Roar of the Wurm in this camp (more on this later.) In this deck in Extended, you need a certain amount of spells that work best when discarded, and they need to be cheap, and good: Deep Analysis serves this task best.

Of course, all this is in addition to the simple fact that it is naturally synergistic with virtually every card in your deck.

4 Daze, 4 Chrome Mox, 0 Waterfront Bouncer, 0 Merfolk Looter: I see U/G, especially the Extended version, as the next evolutionary step from a Fish deck. It has better creatures, and has a much higher degree of endurance; U/Gs creatures kill faster, and aren't as easily stopped by random cards like Masticore, or Cursed Scroll. But deep down, it's still just a Fish deck: cheap creatures, cheap counters.

What this means is that it must be played aggressively with a maximum amount of speed and early disruption because, most of the time, the late game does not belong to it. While I mentioned that in several matchups Deep Analysis is good because the games go long, the deck is still one built to take advantage of the early game. Obviously Daze is best in the opening few turns, as are big creatures. Even though you will rarely run out of cards because of all the card drawing, other decks have deadlier tools than you do in the late game. While you have a backup plan, your goal is still to end it as soon as possible.

This is why cards like Chrome Mox, and Daze are so good in this deck: they help the deck do what its best at, rather than trying to pull it in some other direction. Chrome Mox makes your deck faster, and Daze increases your strength in the most important turns of the game: the early ones. In addition, a nice thing about U/G is that redundant cards (such as the 2nd Mox, or late-game Dazes,) can always be discarded for profit, so theres a decreased risk in playing these early-game specific cards, and theres no good reason not to play four Chrome Moxes (as opposed to just two or three.)

Also of note is that when youre drawing as many cards as this deck does, you want to be able to play your spells as cheaply as possible, regardless of card advantage. Thats why Daze is so strong definitely more crucial than even Circular Logic.

This is also why I feel strongly that cards like Waterfront Bouncer, and Merfolk Looter do not have a place in this deck. While their effects are not negligible, they work to prolong the game, rather than work aggressively to finish it. Functionally, they are basically enchantments: they rarely attack, and when they do its for a pathetic single point of damage. With so many other strong options, I do not think cards that work against the decks gameplan warrant a spot.

Further, while some might say that the deck needs these, for additional madness outlets, I would say that this is untrue for two main reasons. First is that very little spot removal is being played in Extended now, and second is that this version has more card-drawing than usual (in a maximum amount of Deep Analysis, and Intuitions,) so its not difficult to find one of your eight madness enablers if necessary.

This seems like a good opportunity to relate an anecdote about the most savage abuse of Chrome Mox I have ever seen, by an anonymous cheater. I was looking over his shoulder. He had a Chrome Mox in play, with

Aquamoeba imprinted underneath it. His opponent activated Pernicious Deed, and I saw this man slowly tuck his Mox under his lands. On the following turn, the man pulled Aquamoeba imprinted on the Mox into his hand, and played it, using the (blank) Mox. His opponent smiled, totally unaware. Still not satisfied, the turn AFTER that, this man played a Careful Study and DISCARDED the empty Mox, FROM PLAY, and passed the turn with nine cards in his hand, two of them laid neatly across the center of his hand.

That man was my father.

2 Intuition, 2 Wonder: It often seems logical to cut corners by cutting a Wonder, since having 2 Intuitions and 1 would seem like having 3, which is what everyone used to play anyway. I do not think this is correct; if anything, I would suggest that an Intuition be the first to go. It is a huge advantage to be able to have Wonder without having to pay three mana, and successfully resolve Intuition to search for it. Also, as mentioned, this deck needs a certain amount of utility discard spells that can be used for Careful Study, and random Aquamoeba and Mongrel pumps Wonder falls into this category, whereas Intuition does not. I think 2 and 2 is the right balance.

0 Roar of the Wurm, 1 Gigapede: Everyone seems to love Roar. I don't get it. A four mana 6/6 is barely even good in draft these days, let alone in a format with as many easy answers to creatures as this one. It gets Deeded away for free, it dies when it gets bounced, your opponent often knows when it's coming, it's slow, it's expensive, it gets chump blocked by random guys and Wall of Blossoms all day, it doesn't have trample, it dies to Smother, it could get wrecked, stolen, breathed on wrong. A bird could crap on it. I don't like to play cards whose best possible place is under a Chrome Mox. Just say no to Roars. And drugs.

On the other hand, the maindeck Gigapede does pretty much everything that Roar of the Wurm does, while at the same time also being a trump card versus the Rock, and sometimes stealing games against Goblins and RDW.

Still, if I had to cut a card to make room for something, it would probably be Gigapede, or Giggles, as hes affectionately referred to around the office.

0 Unsummon (or Seal of Removal): A recent article advised cutting 4 Daze for 4 Unsummon. While the notion of cutting Daze, quite likely more powerful than Force of Will would be in this deck, is laughable, the author isnt totally off-base. Unsummon is the type of card that works well in this deck, since it is cheap (important when youre drawing a lot of cards,) and has a board effect. It also helps a tough Game 1 in the Reanimator matchup. However, I dont think it belongs for the reason that there is nothing in the deck worth taking out for it; every other card is better, or serves a more diverse purpose. I dont think they belong, but you could do a lot worse than to squeeze a few cheap bounce spells into this deck.

Also, Seal of Removal is just better.

0 Masticore, 0 Genesis: These are cards that I see played a lot in U/G Madness (including Sirons top 8 list, with Masticore,) that superficially look like they would fit right into the deck, but do not actually.

Like Roar of the Wurm, Masticore is expensive and slow. I cant even think of any matchups where its pinging ability would come online in time to be useful. Its regeneration ability seems marginally useful in some matchups, but certainly not enough to warrant playing it in the first place. You cant ever discard it and cast it later, like Roar. The only place Masticore belongs in a U/G deck is on the picture of Deep Analysis. And maybe one with smiley faces drawn on it and autographs to prop up beside your life counter as a good luck charm.

People like to get clever with Genesis, Intuition, and zany silver bullets. I saw one U/G deck sporting the Rebel chain. Dont do that. Keep it simple. The mana

involved in these complex plans is simply not worth the trouble. In the time it would take you to get your Genesis/Gilded Drake engine going, Akroma would've killed you twice. Also, in the case of Genesis, Gigapede seems about twice as good. Why pay 5 to replay an Aquamoeba, when you can pay the same amount and get a 6/1 untargetable? Not to mention that Gigapede serves as an unremovable madness outlet when it's in the yard.

Both Masticore and Genesis suffer from the same problems as Merfolk Looter and Waterfront Bouncer: they are not conducive to the deck's primary strengths. They serve to lengthen the game instead of shorten it, and I think that's a mistake.

0 Ray of Revelation: Ray of Revelation fits right into this deck's gameplan, and works very well with Intuition. However, the fact is, there just aren't really enough enchantments being played to warrant it. It's nice to have versus Deed, but you're already bringing in enough cards. It's decent versus Aluren, but nothing special. It's a good safety against wackos playing Worship, but there aren't really enough going around to make it a necessary precaution, and you can always counter that anyway. Because of the diversity of the current Extended field, sideboard slots are really tight and you have to give up luxuries such as this one.

0 Energy Flux: Affinity is definitely a bad matchup. This card can turn it in your favour, and your odds of finding one (or more) are likely with all the deck's card drawing. It's not useful versus much else though (it is solid versus ScepterTog, but I'm not sure if there's something worth taking out for it.) In Extended, sideboard cards ought to have diverse applications, but you may want to make an exception here if there is a lot of Affinity being played in your area.

0 Chalice of the Void, 0 Equilibrium: These are cards that I considered sideboarding for Reanimator, but neither seemed as good as Seal of Removal, or as

broadly applicable as Gilded Drake. They are options to consider, though.

0 Powder Keg: I ran these in older sideboards, and I see them in lists occasionally. They were kind of a catch-all card, that was supposed to help vs RDWs 1 drops, and Ensnaring Bridge. The entire time I had them, even when I boarded them vs RDW I found them unimpressive; getting an aggressive start, with Chill was far more important than killing a couple Mogg Fanatics, and Bridge isn't really a problem anyway. Maybe now they're worth considering, though, if they're any good versus Affinity. But I doubt it. The cards power level is just not high enough when compared to alternatives for sideboard slots.

19 Land: Someone recently suggested that 23 mana sources (including Moxes,) was too many and that 21 or 22 would suffice. I would advise against this: while 23 is on the high side of the spectrum, it's worth it to ensure you get off the ground properly. Getting mana-stalled, or screwed could easily cost you the game, but with as many card drawers, and discard-outlets, drawing a few too many land won't be a huge issue. Also, 9 Islands is about the minimum for the Wonders and Dazes.

Here are a few notes regarding the matchups, and sideboarding.

RDW: This is a pretty good matchup, probably somewhere around 65% in favour of U/G. The key here is to get a Mongrel in play, and make sure it never dies. Hard cast your Deep Analysis if possible to make sure it always has enough fuel, because as long as they're burning it, they're not burning you, and they're taking damage. I would suggest using countermagic aggressively (ie, countering a burn spell targeting Mongrel with Circular Logic is fine if you're saving a card,) to gain a foothold on the board.

SB:

-2 Wonder

-2 Circular Logic

+4 Chill

Leave in a Wonder and take out a Gigapede if you know or suspect they're bringing in Ensnaring Bridge. Some people board in Flametongue Kavu against you that is garbage and will often usually be stuck in their hand because of Chill, or Dazed. Chill certainly isn't game over they have plenty of colourless spells but it does stunt their growth significantly, and in tandem with a Mongrel is usually enough to win.

Ensnaring Bridge isn't really a big deal because Chills usually gum up their hand. Worst case scenario, you can always Deep Analysis them once or twice if you build up an army.

The Rock: This matchup is all about pacing. Play it carefully and they'll have a tough time beating you. I would guess this is about as good as 80% in U/Gs favour.

Don't overextend too much into Pernicious Deed. Two creatures is generally a good number. Fly over blockers with Wonder, and if you have enough creatures in play, spend the turn playing Deep Analysis. Almost always hardcast your Analysis in this matchup.

If the opportunity arises, Intuition for Gigapede.

Don't let the Circular Logics build up in your hand it's what they almost always call with Cabal Therapy. Burn them to gain an advantage.

SB: -2 Daze, -2 Circular Logic, +4 Submerge

The Logics come out because they are almost always called with Cabal Therapy. This way you have the advantage of having a couple Logics, but without the possibility of having them clump in your hand and getting wrecked. Most Rock decks play a ton of land, which is why Daze isn't as good as normal.

A trick with Submerge to remember: Often the best time to play it on a Bird of Paradise is inside their draw

step, but after they've drawn. That way they can't replay the Bird that turn, and by the time they draw it next turn, the mana acceleration is much less relevant.

Goblins: Goblins is not a very good matchup. Probably about 60% in their favour (Chills help a ton.) Sparksmith, Goblin Sharpshooter, and Living Death are all spells that pose trouble. Your best hope is to get a quick Mongrel/Moeba-Arrogant Wurm draw. You also have the backup plan of Wonder-Gigapede. You want to go as aggro as possible in this matchup, because Goblins late game is overwhelming.

SB: -4 Circular Logic +4 Chill

Reanimator: Game 1, Reanimator is a terrible matchup, but it is very very good after board. All told, I would say this matchup is about 60% in U/Gs favour. Maybe slightly lower.

Game 1, you can hope to get lucky with a Daze or Logic, and kill them before they can find another reanimation spell, or you can deal with their fatties. Phantom Nishoba is a pain, but if you just keep throwing guys in front of it (like Mongrels and Rootwallas, which mess with their Trample damage math,) until it's small enough to be blocked by an Arrogant Wurm, you'll be fine. Just one Nishoba is not enough. Rorix and Akroma can be caught with a Wondered Wild Mongrel, if you have time to set that up.

SB: -1 Gigapede, -2 Wonder, -1 Circular Logic, -3 Daze +3 Seal of Removal +4 Gilded Drake

Almost every spell in their deck costs one mana so Daze is not at its best. I might keep in one or two on the play, though.

The goal here is just to get some pressure going, and a Seal of Removal on the table. It's difficult for them to know exactly what to do because your answers are so diverse (counters, drake, seal,) and because you see so many cards in-between their Duresses and

Therapies.

Affinity: Man, did U/G ever get outdated once Affinity came along. All of a sudden U/G is like the 8-track of beatdown decks.

Suitably, Affinity is one of U/Gs worst matchups, both before and after board. The Extended Affinity deck seems slower than the standard one, so I guess the plan is to come out as fast as possible, hopefully with a Mox, and get Wonder. I dont even think thats a sure thing though.

SB: -1 Gigapede +1 Seal of Removal

I might cut a Daze or something for a couple more Seal of Removals, depending if Im on the play or draw.

If you want to turn this matchup positive, add 3 or 4 Energy Flux into the sideboard. Their better in U/G than they are in most decks, since U/Gs putting pressure on while the Flux is up, and because U/G draws more cards than most decks.

Without Flux, Id say its as bad as 20%.

Psychatog: Its a bit of a challenge to give matchup advice for Psychatog, since it varies so much from build to build. Basically, though, Pyschatog decks fall into two camps: ScepterTog (which is strong in the current metagame, and was popularized last season,) and Old-School U/B Tog (which sucks, and was invented in the early eighties.)

Oddly, Sceptertog is a great matchup for U/G, and U/B Tog can be a difficult one, depending how dedicated they are to their weird, outdated creature removal strategy. If the U/B Tog deck can consistently kill your Madness outlets, it wont be easy.

ScepterTog is an easier matchup because it plays very few removal spells, relying instead on a Sceptered Fire and Ice. This is usually just too slow and ineffective against U/G. Also ScepterTog is usually

lower on cards in hand because of Chrome Moxes and Scepters, so the Tog itself is less deadly.

Daze is at its absolute best in both matchups. Remember that neither deck has mass removal so get every creature you can out there.

SB: -1 Arrogant Wurm, -2 Circular Logic +3 Seal of Removal (vs U/B.) No change vs Sceptertog.

U/Gs about 75% versus ScepterTog, and about 50% versus a dedicated U/B build.

Mirror: I think the U/G mirror match is one of the most complicated ones there is. Its the magic that reminds me most of chess. I believe play skill is a huge factor.

I remember watching Ken Ho and Ben Rubin test for Worlds 2003 in Berlin, playing the U/G Mirror. Ken won the first game, and Ben said Ken drew his Wonders. Ken won the second game, and Ben said Ken drew his Unsummons. Ken won the third game, and Ben said, Ken drew his Circular Logics. By the time Ken won the fourth game, Ben was out of cards to blame. This is not to say that Ben is bad at the U/G mirror, just that Ken is a master, nay, THE master, and that there is a considerable level of skill involved in what can off-handedly appear to just be a random aggro versus aggro match.

All sorts of different types of situations come up in this mirror match, but I think Ive found a general rule of thumb: card advantage is huge. I used to think it was all tempo, and that Waterfront Bouncer was the best card in the mirror. Since Ive done more testing, Ive reconsidered. What you want to do, ideally, is get your Madness outlets and Wurms out of your hand as soon as possible, and then draw as many cards as possible, while making land drops. Barring any Wonder disparity, the player who is able to fuel his madness cards best will win. This is especially true in Extended, where most U/G mirrors dont have instant bounce to steal games. Waterfront Bouncer is good, but

unless you have serious pressure to back it up, you'll eventually be overwhelmed.

SB: -1 Gigapede, -2 Intuition, -2 Aquamoeba, -2 Wonder, +4 Submerge +3 Gilded Drake

The idea behind this bizarre looking sideboard plan is that, after board, the matchup is less about beatdown draws, and long card advantage wars, and more about screwing your opponent. Gilded Drake either takes their Waterfront Bouncer, or their Mongrel, ideally stranding Madness cards in their hand. This is why Wonders can go they are no longer as relevant to the game. Aquamoebas are less necessary since they are mediocre in combat, and because other Madness outlets aren't likely to be removed.

To be honest though, there are many different ways you can board this deck in the mirror, and I'm not entirely sure which way is right.

There are many variations to this plan, so evaluate each deck individually. For instance, if your opponent is playing a three colour version of the deck with few Forests, obviously Submerge isn't a great idea.

Minds Desire: I've been reading all over the Internet that Minds Desire is supposedly a good matchup for U/G, but I don't really see it. I played one at PT Columbus and I got demolished.

The best you can hope to do is counter their Medallion-type cards, and hope to kill them quickly, but other than that, their combo is untouchable.

You also don't really have anything to bring in. This is where Stifles would come in handy.

I can't see this matchup being better than 30% for U/G.

To sum it up:

U/G Madness is a deck with fast creatures, and

counterspells, fueled and made resilient by card-drawing. Sometimes all the card-drawing and counterspells gives people the wrong idea. This deck is a beatdown deck at heart, not a control deck. It wants to win in the early game. Playing cards that help it win in the early game, while at the same time have an effect in the midgame when youre drawing a ton of cards, will make the deck win more.

Most Extended decks are mean. Most Extended decks want to do sick, sick things to other decks. U/G just attacks with strange and wonderful woodland creatures. The longer you spend fooling around being cute with Thought Courier, or your Squee-Compulsion, or your Genesis-HanaKami-ReachThroughtheMists engines, the higher risk you run of being nuclear bombed by a real combo.

Know what this deck is at heart, and youll win more with it. Dont let anyone try to sell you a build full of random bells and whistles, stay streamlined and efficient.

All that said, if I was playing in a PTQ tomorrow, I dont think I would play U/G. I do not think U/G is a bad choice, I think it is a good choice. However, I think the best choice would either be a ScepterChant control deck (like Cabral de Costas from the Top 16 of Pro Tour Columbus,) or a ScepterTog deck, both of which seem strong versus most decks, and have a couple dominant matchups versus popular decks RDW and Reanimator, and whose natural enemy, Rock, is on the downswing.

If I had a chance to test it enough, Id probably play something like this:

ffeJatog

- 3 Daze
- 1 Orim's Chant
- 3 Cunning Wish
- 2 Engineered Plague
- 3 Fact or Fiction
- 2 Flooded Strand

1 Plains
9 Island
2 Swamp
4 Polluted Delta
4 Sulfurous Springs
4 Chrome Mox
4 Brainstorm
4 Isochron Scepter
2 Vampiric Tutor
4 Fire/Ice
4 Counterspell
4 Psychatog
SB: 1 Orim's Chant
SB: 1 Ensnare
SB: 1 Fact or Fiction
SB: 1 Fling
SB: 1 Vampiric Tutor
SB: 1 Stifle
SB: 1 Boomerang
SB: 1 Chalice of the Void
SB: 4 Chill
SB: 1 Overload
SB: 1 Energy Flux
SB: 1 Cranial Extraction

Good luck, and cya all in Nagoya

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